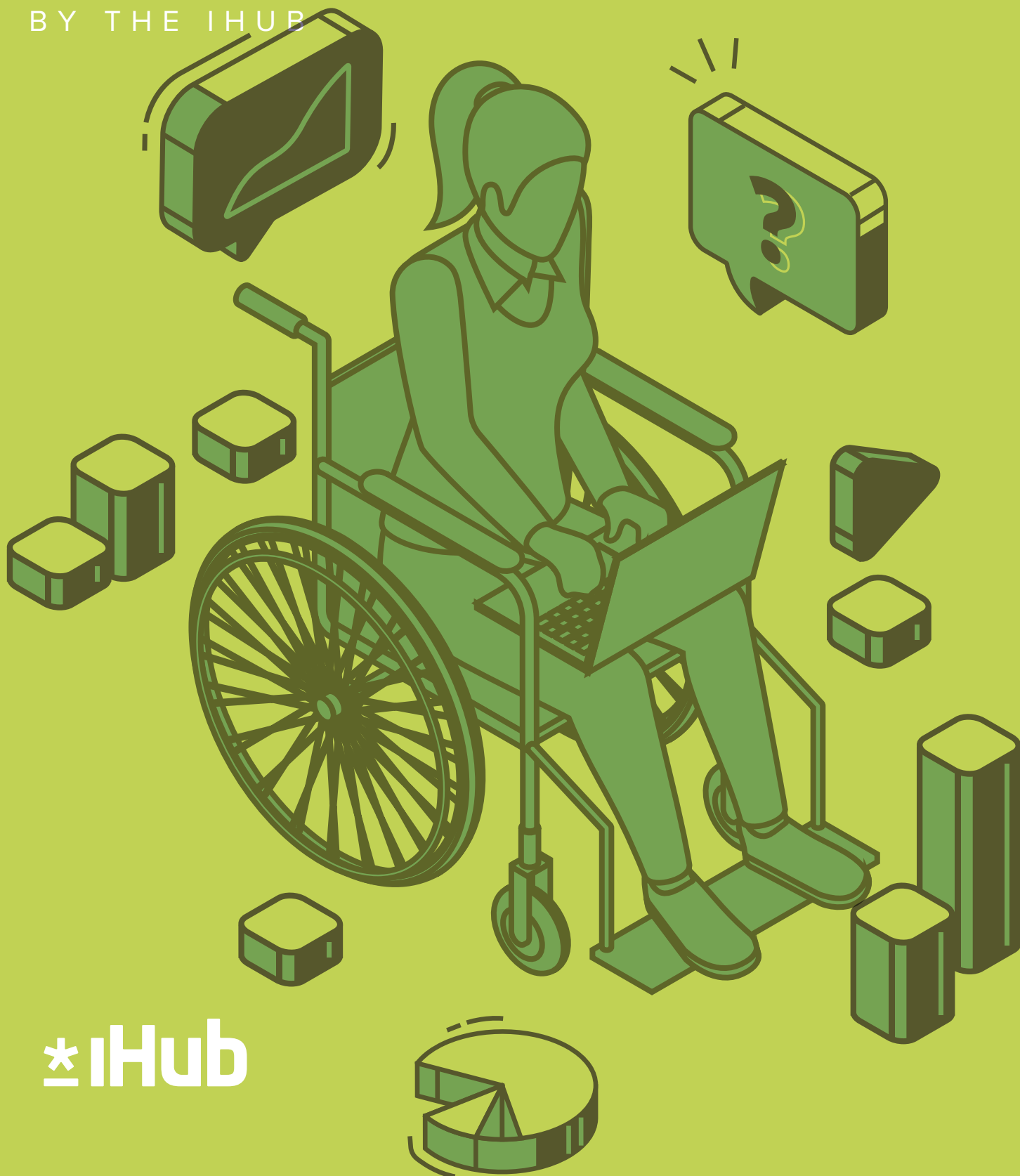


SURVIVING THE DIGITAL AGE AS A YOUNG WOMAN WITH DISABILITY

BY THE IHUB



***IHub**

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PART I

RISKS AND REWARDS OF BEING ONLINE AS A YOUNG WOMAN WITH DISABILITY

The Internet is...

What do you mainly use the internet for?
What is a typical time online for you like?
What apps or websites do you like? Why?

When I started using the internet, I didn't know...

Activity 1

What are some of the things you wish you knew about the internet, social media apps etc before you became a frequent user?

REWARDS OF BEING ONLINE

- Has the internet changed any aspect of your life?
- What do you enjoy most about being online?
- Are there benefits you personally gain from being online?
- Are there ways you think the internet has made your community better?

RISKS OF BEING ONLINE

Activity 2

Personally, what do you think are some of the risks of being online as a young woman living with a disability?

While there are countless benefits of being online, there are factors that may demotivate one from participating on online platforms. This could be truer for you, as a young woman with disability. The types of risks that you may face or consider when navigating digital spaces can be categorized into three main types;



Contact Risks

These are issues that arise from the people with whom we come into contact. A lot of older citizens and scam artists tend to pose as younger citizens, sometimes even children, to take advantage of their target victims. For young women trying to navigate social media platforms, this is especially more worrying given the number of warnings one receives.



Content Risks

Content risks arise from the content that users come across and interact with regularly on online platforms.

Some of the risks include pornography, simulated violence such as in online fighting games e.g Fortnite, gambling such as in betting which is majorly done online now.



Conduct Risks

These are risks that are associated with either how we conduct ourselves while online, or how other individuals carry themselves while online.

Some of the issues we can cluster as conduct risks include: cyber bullying, sending and receiving of intimate text messages, images, videos and films (also known as sexting), using of other people's financial information for unconsented or illegal purchases, using of other people's personal information to set up social media profiles which is a form of doxxing (addressed in Part III of this document)

PART II

IDENTITY AND PRIVACY

Introduction

How does your identity as a person with disability affect your daily interactions on the internet?
Have you used or tried using dating apps, working out apps etc?
Have you tried joining other online communities? What communities are these?
What was your experience navigating these spaces?
What would you say was good or bad about these spaces?
What does online privacy mean to you?
Can you remember any moments where you felt your privacy was respected?
Do you think your privacy is invaded upon sometimes while online?
In what ways have you experienced an invasion of your privacy while interacting with people on social media apps?



Identity

Identity with regards to the internet can be defined loosely as the social persona that one embodies as they navigate online spaces and platforms. This persona is constructed by the user using characteristics that they consider desirable or unique for themselves. Some people are identified by the issues they discuss, address or content they share such as activist, feminist, artist.

What other identity can you think of?

While on the internet, one can be anyone or whoever they would like to be, their choices are not limited. Have you seen social media accounts with profile pictures of celebrities, or of people claiming to work in made-up companies? In addition to this, some users tend to use avatars or not disclose their personal details so as to avoid being targeted for who they are in real life. While this is great for someone avoiding targeted harassment, it is also dangerous as it gives dangerous people the opportunity to mask into other personas so as to take advantage of unsuspecting individuals. This is known as catfishing (refer to Part III)

There are individuals who have been locked out of spaces or communities because of their identity. There are people who have been victims of cyberbullying because of their identity. Do you know anyone who has been a victim of online harassment because of how they identify?



Privacy

How would you define privacy? What about online privacy? What are some of the apps you like to use? Do you believe your personal information is being protected while you use these apps?

Online privacy in the simplest terms can be defined as the protection of one's personal information and personal data while navigating online spaces. Every time you use your computer or smartphone to visit websites or launch apps, you leave behind traces of

digital footprints, such as government names, geo-location, credit card details etc which companies and data enthusiasts (and sometimes, malicious individuals) collect, process and store for their own purposes including targeted advertising, and for sponsorship.

While the collection of this data is inevitable, if not well protected it can be accessible to other dangerous parties including hackers, scam artists etc who can use this information for other criminal and malicious purposes.

PART III

ONLINE SAFETY AND DIGITAL HYGIENE

The internet has its many rewards and gratifications, but clearly it can also be a scary and cruel place filled with vices, especially for a woman.

You may therefore ask,

Can I Protect My Identity and Privacy and Still Reap the Benefits of Being Online?

The answer is yes.

Here are some considerations to ensure your privacy and security online:



Password Management

Good password management is essential to ensuring that malicious individuals do not hijack your online accounts and use them for their dubious purposes (like committing fraud). It is therefore a good password practice to use strong, complex passwords and to change them periodically. It is also an important practice and critical that no two passwords (e.g, for email and Instagram) are the same. This way hackers and other intruders are unable to access all your information across different online platforms in the event that one of them (say Facebook) gets hacked.

These essential password practices clearly come with a challenge: remembering long, complex passwords to multiple online accounts.

This challenge is addressed by tools called password managers, which are softwares that help you (yes, you guessed right) manage your slew of passwords. This includes creating strong passwords, storing them in secure vaults and helping you authenticate securely to your accounts without having to memorize or remember the passwords.

Some really good password managers you can try today include 1Password, Dashlane, LastPass and Keeper.

Besides using a password manager, enabling two-factor authentication (2FA) ensures increased security for your online accounts by adding something you know or have as an extra means of verification (this might be your phone number or an authentication app like Authy).

You can learn how to enable 2FA on any of your online accounts [here](#).



Privacy-friendly Browsers and Search Engines

Another way that you can ensure that your personal information and data is protected while using the internet is by using non-tracking browsers and search engines that respect your privacy.

Browsers



Search Engines



Update Your Devices

It is very easy to hack into devices whose software has not been updated to include the latest security measures by the manufacturer. This is why you should always update your software as soon as you receive a notification. This goes a long way in preventing security breaches on devices.



If Possible, Avoid Public Devices and Networks

When you use a computer at a cyber cafe, be careful not to save your passwords on the computer or leave any sensitive personal information on them. This includes your identification number, your government names, passport details, credit card numbers among other things. Where possible, use private (incognito) windows so as to not leave traces of your activities behind.

This also applies to using public WiFi networks at malls, airports, on public transport and even restaurants. Public networks are generally insecure and information one sends over them can easily be hijacked by hackers.

To protect yourself while using public networks, keep HTTPs and VPNs in mind.



HTTPs and Virtual Private Networks (VPN)

Securely browsing the web is made possible by encryption. Encryption on the web is implemented with a protocol known as HTTPs (or Hypertext Transfer Protocol secure). Unfortunately, HTTPs isn't implemented by default, so internet users must pay attention to the websites they visit for signs of HTTPs which is usually a padlock icon or https in the url bar of the website.

Although some websites do not have HTTPs implemented, you can ensure a secure connection to every website by installing the extension HTTPs Everywhere (it comes by default if you use the Tor or Brave browser).

Virtual Private Networks, VPN, is a technology that protects data or information sent over a network by encrypting them. It is advisable to use VPNs when using a public network, especially if you will be sending sensitive information like credit card details (e.g during an online purchase).

Some good VPN options to try today: Lantern, Tunnel Bear, Psiphon, Express VPN, NordVPN



Digital Detox

In protecting your personal information on online spaces, it is important to know in whose custody your information is. A digital detox is basically the practice of clearing out personal information from devices and platforms that you no longer use. This could include deleting old accounts that you no longer want to exist.

A digital detox also means that you check the permissions that you give each app and/or website on your device and revoking the permissions to some information that you no longer wish the app or site to have. In addition to this, it is also key to clear cookies from each platform so as to avoid the continuous collection of specific data.

The benefits of a digital detox include that you have healthier devices, you are more aware of what information is being collected and you reduce the access that third parties have to your devices and online accounts.

A privacy-focused, digital detox program can be found [here](#)



Oversharing is Over Caring

While we may think that sharing a lot of information over the internet is a great way to form bonds with others, this could actually work to your disadvantage. There are a lot of dangerous people lurking over the internet looking for the next victim of their devious acts. Therefore always limit the information you share with people online, regardless of whether you know them or not. For starters, do not share your live location with anyone online. If you want to talk about a certain event or activity you are taking part in, do this after the event is over.

This also includes sharing images with sensitive information such as your credit card, your phone number, your car number plate, your plane ticket or your passport details etc.

RISK ASSESSMENT

Risk assessment is a vital part of information security and precedes the technical, managerial and administrative controls put in place for the protection of information or assets.

Risk, in simple terms, is the likelihood of loss or damage to an asset, and is measured as:

Risk = Threat x Vulnerability x Value

Threat is anything that has a potential to harm an asset.

Vulnerability is a weakness or flaw in/around an asset that can be exploited by a threat actor.

Value is the perceived or actual worth of an asset.

Example to Measure Risk



Equal Rights is a human rights organisation in Uganda that advocates for the rights of LGBTQ individuals, especially women. Uganda has an anti-homosexual act and its government is vehemently against gays. Its public is also violently homophobic too, and the lynching and physical assault of “offenders” is a common sight in Uganda’s city of Kampala, where Equal Rights is headquartered.

Equal Rights has a monthly meetup for LGBTQ people called Hers & Hers, held in secret random locations each time communicated to members via a closed Telegram group.

Q 1: How would you measure the risk on member's lives who attend Hers & Hers?

Q2: What are some recommendations you will give to Equal Rights for better safety (digital and physical) of its operations and members?

Answers

A 1: Let's start by defining our parameters (maximum value is 10, minimum value is 1).

Risk = Threat x Vulnerability x Value

Threats could be:

- Angry Homophobic Mob/Individuals
- State Security apparatus (Police, Secret Service, etc)
- Insider Threat (Someone at Equal Rights revealing the location of the next meetup)
- Negligence of members or the Equal Rights team in securing their phones where locations and names may be found

We recall that Uganda is highly homophobic which makes the possibility of a mob attack or arrests high. Negligence is also a very strong possibility especially when people are not fully aware of consequences. Putting this together, we will assign our threat a fairly high score of 9.

Threat = 9

The following vulnerabilities are considered:

- Poor access control (e.g, poorly manned gates, unchecked access/entries)
- Weak doors
- No hidden exits or safe areas
- No physical guards
- Building's susceptibility to physical attacks and pressure
- Backup power (e.g, if light gets disconnected on the outside, does the biometric control go out? Is there an instant backup power to protect against this?)
- No passwords on member's phone (thus making it easy for third parties to view apps and sensitive information.)
- Unpatched/un-updated phones, thus making it easy to spy on members' communication.
- No legal backup (incase of arrests)

The vulnerabilities can be endless, but since we are working with a hypothetical situation (not having details such as the type of doors or access control at the location), we will assign vulnerabilities an average score of 5.

Vulnerability = 5

Value: What is the worth or importance of our asset? You can rephrase that and say what is the worth of a human life?
Without saying, we will assign this a value of 10.

Value = 10

From our formula, Risk = Threat x Vulnerability x Value

Risk = 9 x 5 x 10 = 540

A risk score of 540 from a possible high score of 1,000 is quite high, and to reduce that, the Vulnerability must be mitigated against (since, most times the Threats are not within the control of an individual/organization and Value is the worth or importance of the asset to the individual/organisation and does not readily fluctuate in value/score)

Activity: How would you measure the risk of a young queer woman on social media in Kenya in terms of digital and mental safety? (Feel free to do this by city)

RISK MAPPING

Risk Mapping is a conceptual, analytical method for identifying and prioritizing risks using a risk matrix.

The matrix measures risk by plotting a graph of Severity (or Impact) against Likelihood (or Probability of occurrence) as shown below

RISK ASSESSMENT MATRIX

		RISK RATING KEY			
		LOW 0 – ACCEPTABLE OK TO PROCEED	MEDIUM 1 – ALARP (as low as reasonably practicable) TAKE MITIGATION EFFORTS	HIGH 2 – GENERALLY UNACCEPTABLE SEEK SUPPORT	EXTREME 3 – INTOLERABLE PLACE EVENT ON HOLD
		SEVERITY			
		ACCEPTABLE LITTLE TO NO EFFECT ON EVENT	TOLERABLE EFFECTS ARE FELT, BUT NOT CRITICAL TO OUTCOME	UNDESIRABLE SERIOUS IMPACT TO THE COURSE OF ACTION AND OUTCOME	INTOLERABLE COULD RESULT IN DISASTER
LIKELIHOOD	IMPROBABLE RISK IS UNLIKELY TO OCCUR	LOW – 1 –	MEDIUM – 4 –	MEDIUM – 6 –	HIGH – 10 –
	POSSIBLE RISK WILL LIKELY OCCUR	LOW – 2 –	MEDIUM – 5 –	HIGH – 8 –	EXTREME – 11 –
	PROBABLE RISK WILL OCCUR	MEDIUM – 3 –	HIGH – 7 –	HIGH – 9 –	EXTREME – 12 –

PART IV

ONLINE VIOLENCE AS I EXPERIENCE IT

Introduction

Have you heard about the term “online violence” before?

Do you think it is real? Does it exist?

How would you define online violence?

What are the examples of online violence do you know?

Have you or someone you know experienced any form of online violence?

Definition

Online violence can be defined as the use of online digital devices, tools and services to cause physical, emotional and/or psychological harm to another individual.

FORMS OF ONLINE VIOLENCE

Do you know of any form of online violence? Which one ?

Here are some common forms in which online violence is exhibited.



Doxxing

This is named after documents or docs. It is the act of releasing someone’s Personal Identifiable Information (PII) without their knowledge and/or consent. PII includes full name as appears on legal documents such as your ID or passport, phone number, home address, passport number and even where one works.

A person that uses this tactic, ie, a doxxer, uses any information that they come across on the internet that can be used against their target victim. This may even include their parents’ or siblings’ details!

The main purpose of the doxxer in this case, is to publish information that other harassers can use against the victim and to intimidate the victim by invading their privacy.

Do you know someone whose personal identifiable information has been released without their consent?



Trolling

Trolls are culprits of starting quarrels or fights amongst people on the internet to distract them from the serious issue being discussed. For example, on a blog post or on an online discussion, the troll will be making snide remarks, which may be insensitive, inflammatory or very off-topic comments which will trigger emotions in the other participants.

The purpose of trolling is usually to cause distress or humiliation and to drive specific individuals off the internet.

Trolling can be done by total strangers or individuals well known to the victim.



Swatting

Swatting is the act of deceiving emergency services for either amusement or a specific personal gain. This form of online violence usually exhibits itself in someone mentioning an emergency deployment service such as the police or the ambulance services as a way of causing panic in another person's social media platform.

This can also be exhibited as a person with a close relationship with the victim posting a false death or accident, or even bomb scare. Have you seen this on your social media?



Cyberstalking

This is the use of the internet to stalk and/or harass individuals, groups or even organizations. This includes the monitoring of their online activity which may then translate into offline actions, taking a screenshot of their pictures, tweets and even messages, solicitation of financial and sexual favours, and identity theft.

The purpose of cyberstalking is to intimidate, harass and embarrass the target victims. The perpetrator of stalking is usually out to control and influence the actions of a victim, both online and offline.



Impersonation

Impersonation is the act of stealing one's online and sometimes offline identity with the intent of reducing their legitimacy to people known to them or people who would like to be acquainted with them.

Impersonation usually happens with celebrities and other famous and popular individuals. The perpetrator is usually out to solicit financial and sometimes sexual gains from their victims by pretending to offer favours as the celebrities they are purporting to be.



Catfishing

Catfishing is quite similar to impersonation only that in this case, the culprits usually steal the online profiles of random strangers from the web or even distant relatives.

This often happens with individuals who are not quite comfortable with their real life personalities, for one reason or another, so they steal the profiles of individuals that may be considered more relatable. This is usually for malicious gain, either to revenge against their victims, to solicit financial and/or sexual gains, and sometimes to seek romantic relationships online.



Dissemination of intimate or private images and videos without consent.

In common terms, it is referred to as "revenge porn". This is the sharing of an individual's intimate, explicit or private images or videos without their consent and/or knowledge, and which would not otherwise be shared with the public.

This is especially rampant in relationships that were not fruitful, or did not work in favour of the culprit. This material may have been created with the knowledge and/or consent of the victim, but is shared unbeknownst to them. The graphic content tends to be accompanied by personal identifiable information of the victim including their legal names, their work address and even their home address, their social media platforms etc.



Discrimination

This is targeted harassment towards an individual/citizen group and even organization on the basis of their race, religion, ability and gender etc. This kind of online violence is manifested through abusive slurs and doxxing sometimes.

The perpetrators of this act, do so with the intent to control and influence the actions of, and embarrass the target victims.

This is extremely dangerous as it leads, more often than not, to physical violence.

EFFECTS OF ONLINE VIOLENCE

Just like physical violence, online violence has adverse effects on the victims that suffer. There are great physical and psychological damages to any form of online violence that occurs.

Here are some of the effects:-

- **Self-censorship**

Many people tend to limit their contribution on online platforms when they are harassed because they feel they no longer have the freedom to express themselves fully. They reduce their activity and only choose to post when they feel it is completely necessary.

- **Detaching/Deactivation from Online Platforms**

Some victims of online abuse could choose to do away with their social media accounts completely as a form of self-preservation and to avoid their mental health deteriorating any further.

- **Separation of Identities**

Some people opt to create separate accounts so as to share different types of content with their different target audiences. For example, one may opt to create an official account where they only post about their work or careers and another account which they only disclose to their close family members and friends.

- **Physical Harm**

Some culprits follow up on online abuse with physical attacks on their victims. Female internet users are severely more affected by this for posting or sharing content that their male counterparts do not encourage. This includes female journalists, human rights defenders and activists and feminists.

HOW CAN WE REDUCE THE CASES OF ONLINE VIOLENCE IN OUR ONLINE COMMUNITIES?



Report, Mute and Block

While we may want to be tolerant of other people's views, self-preservation while navigating social media platforms is key. Do not be afraid of reporting accounts or content that you perceive to be harmful to yourself or others. Beyond this, you are encouraged to curate your social media feed to see and consume content that makes you happy, educates you and reflects positively on your life. This could include muting and blocking accounts that evoke negative emotions in you.



Legal Action

There are ways in which one can seek legal redress when they have experienced a form of online violence. This could include getting restraining orders and punitive measures against the culprit such as fines and jail time.



Share The Resources

Some women may be getting abused and violated while online but do not know the effective measures they can take against the perpetrators. Creating online safe spaces

PART V

BUILDING A BETTER AND MORE INCLUSIVE INTERNET

Introduction

What would a perfect internet be like to you?

What are some good practices we can begin to adapt as we navigate the internet space?

What are some of the resources we can turn to ?

Feminist Principles of the Internet

A perfect internet space is one which empowers and encourages more women to participate in any online discourse regardless of their attributes. This means that women should be able to enjoy any platform they would like to be a part of or even create their own spaces and social networks as it pleases them.

The Feminist Principles of the Internet as designed by Take Back The Tech looks at five main aspects that go along way to improve the quality of experiences that women have. These five aspects are:



Access

Every woman deserves to have access to the same online platforms, and information as every other person regardless of their age, disability and even sexual orientation. This includes access to important information such as reproductive health and even educational and career opportunities. A fairer internet is one that fully, affordably, fairly and openly empowers all women who access it.

Access also means that women and queer persons have the right to code, design, adapt and critically and sustainably use ICTs and reclaim technology as a platform for creativity and expression, as well as to challenge the cultures of sexism and discrimination in all spaces.



Movements and Public Participation

A feminist internet space is one that ensures that all women are empowered to take part in the shaping of important spaces both online and offline. This means that they should be able to create tables where they can shape the policies that govern the internet and equally resist and challenge norms that are patriarchal and misogynistic in nature.

Basically, formulating laws and policies in internet governance should be a democratic decision-making process in which all women should be involved.



Expression

A feminist internet is one that guarantees each woman the right and freedom to express themselves and their lived realities as they please and would like to without any fear of harassment or abuse.

This entails resisting the silencing and persecution of hypervisible feminists and women human rights defenders, resisting moral policing and censorship of women who are

are comfortable with themselves and resisting and decentering the patriarchal gaze when it comes to women's and queer people's desires.



Economy

A feminist internet is one in which economies are built on equal access to economic opportunities fueled and driven by cooperation, collaboration and freedom in sharing.



Embodiment

"This principle looks at women's diverse experiences and relationships as human beings embodying multiple identities and realities in "disembodied" online spaces." This includes having a consent-by-design outlook when developing policies, and in designing and building online platforms so that women constantly have agency when navigating these platforms. This also means that when a woman wants to navigate the internet as an anonymous entity, their right is guaranteed and respected. It also includes ensuring that each woman's right to their privacy and control of their personal data is always respected.

A feminist online space ensures that when a woman's rights are violated and they are victims of any form of technology-assisted violence, there are punitive measures in place that ensure the perpetrator does not get away with any of their actions. At the same time, such a space also ensures that there is after care for women who have been victims of this violence.

Creating Codes of Conduct

Another practice we can adapt while navigating online communities and forums, especially those limited to specific users, is encouraging the use of codes of conduct. A code of conduct is a set of guidelines that outlines how the community members or users of a platform are expected to carry themselves as they interact with the rest of the users. This entails highlighting what is permissible and what is not. It also entails what course of action will be pursued if this code is breached.

This is critically important as it ensures that the participating users are respectful and accommodating of other users and holds them accountable for each of their actions.

How else can we build a better and more inclusive internet for women across the world?

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